Privacy

How safe is Telegram in 2025? What you should know, and how to protect yourself

Why the popular messaging app is a big fail for your privacy

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June 7, 2025
7 mins read

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Telegram is a popular messaging app known for its speed, multi-platform availability, and group chats, some of which have been the subject of controversy. But while it markets itself as a private messenger, Telegram comes up way short on the list of messengers with privacy protection

If you're using Telegram to keep your conversations private, you might be surprised at how much data is still exposed. Nym is here to help you take steps to protect yourself on Telegram.

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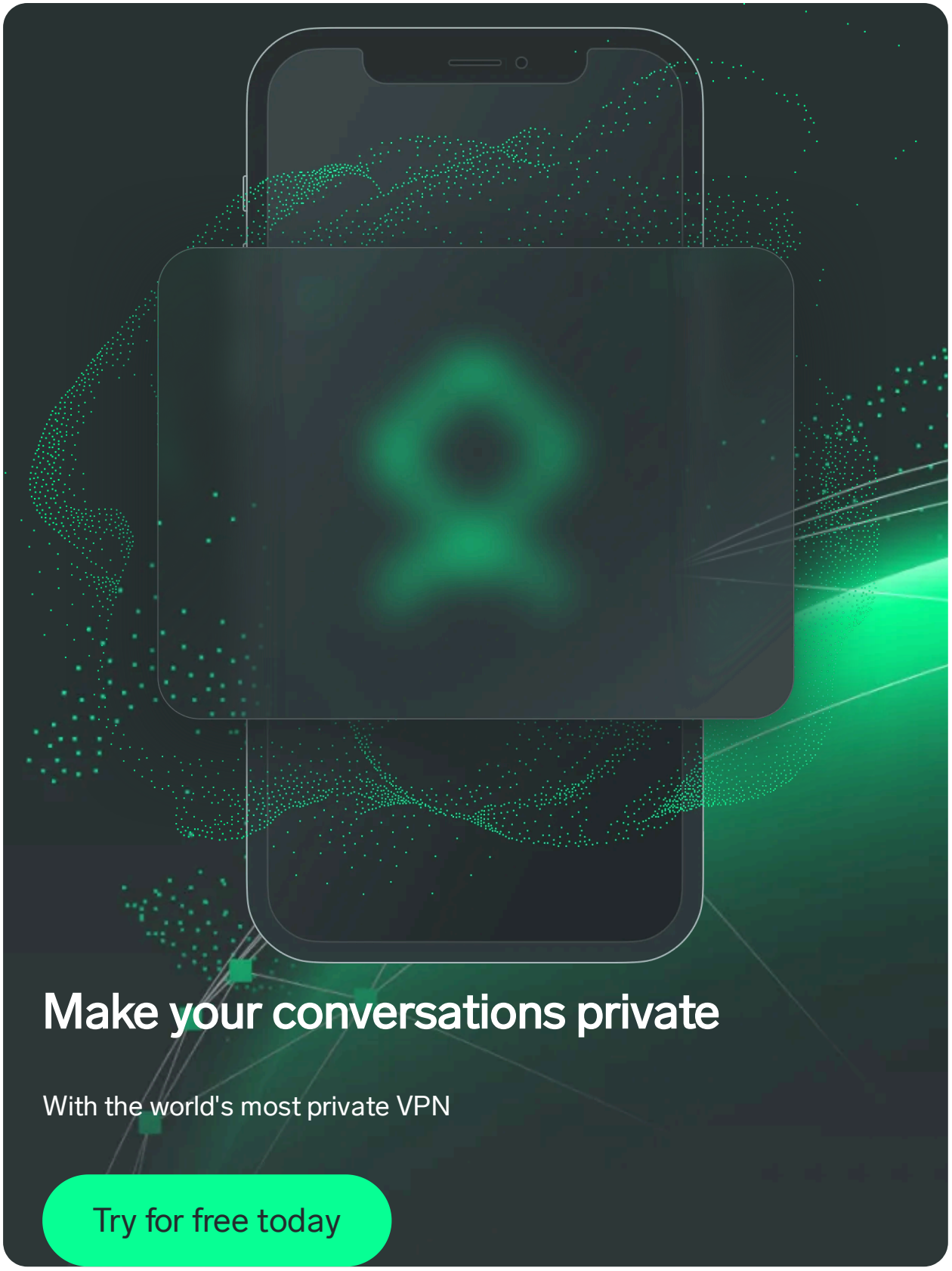

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Unlike competing apps like Signal and WhatsApp, **Telegram does not offer default end-to-end (e2e) encryption for all chats. Only its **Secret Chats** use this level of protection, and you must enable them manually. Regular chats are stored on Telegram's servers and are encrypted only in transit.

This means that Telegram — and anyone with access to their servers — can read your messages **unless you're using Secret Chats**. If you're communicating anything sensitive with Telegram, make sure it's in Secret Chat mode.

Cloud-based convenience with privacy tradeoffs

Telegram's cloud-based model allows you to access your messages across devices easily. But this convenience comes at the cost of **server-side data storage**. This means that the content of your chats will be at risk if Telegram's servers are ever compromised.

These stored messages are **not end-to-end encrypted** and could potentially be accessed by Telegram, hackers, or governments requesting user data.

Metadata and IP address exposure

Even if you use Secret Chats, Telegram still logs metadata such as contact interactions, timestamps, and of course your IP address. These logs can be used to reconstruct your communication patterns and even reveal your location or identity: all despite any encryption.

To prevent this type of surveillance, pair Telegram with tools that mask your network activity, like a decentralized VPN (dVPN).

Is Telegram open source?

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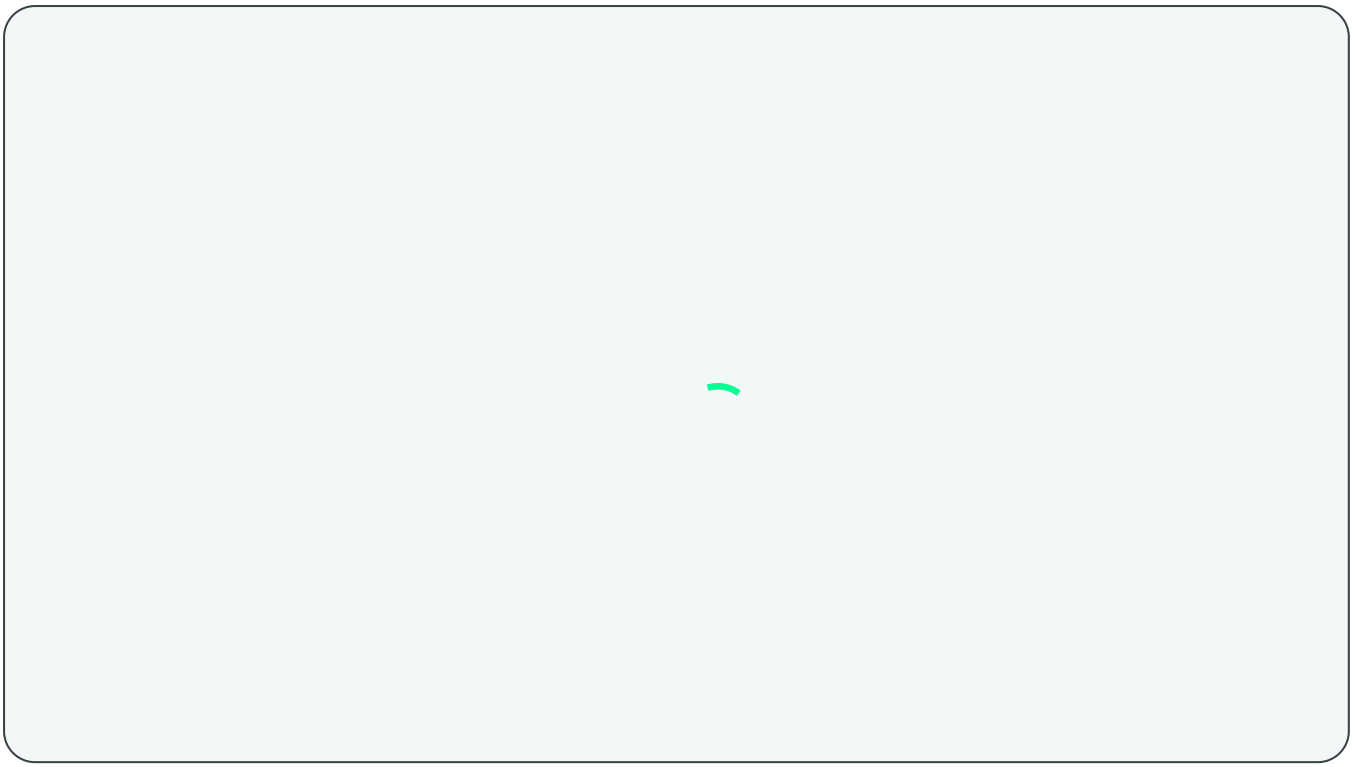
— is closed-source.

Without full open-source transparency, users can't verify what's happening with their data on the backend. This leaves room for potential vulnerabilities or backdoors.



What is open source?

Telegram's group chats reconsidered

Telegram's group chats can host thousands of members, making them powerful for organizing. Unfortunately, these chats are not always private. By default, **group messages are not end-to-end encrypted**, meaning Telegram and anyone in the chat can read them if it chooses or is compelled to.

Additionally, group metadata — such as participant lists, message timestamps, and IP addresses — can be logged and stored. This can pose risks for users participating in politically sensitive or high-risk groups.

But there are things you can do to protect your privacy in group chats:

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- Use Secret Chats for one-on-one coordination instead
- Pair Telegram with NymVPN to mask your IP address and obscure your digital trail from malicious actors

Telegram and contact syncing: A hidden risk

Telegram automatically asks to sync your contact list to help you find friends. While this can be convenient, it also means **Telegram stores your entire contact book on its servers**, including names, phone numbers, and metadata like who you've messaged.

Even if your contacts don't use Telegram, their information may be stored and potentially exposed if Telegram is ever breached. To disable contact syncing:

1. Go to **Settings > Privacy** and **Security > Data Settings**
2. Toggle off **Sync Contacts** and **delete synced data**

Telegram privacy vulnerabilities

As we've seen, Telegram has a number of known privacy weaknesses:

- **Lack of default end-to-end encryption:** Unless you're using Secret Chats, your conversations are stored on Telegram's servers and can be accessed.
- **Closed-source backend:** Without public access to the server code, it's impossible to verify what happens to your data.
- **IP and metadata logging:** Telegram records your IP address, contact interactions, and other metadata, which could be used to track you.
- **Cloud storage of messages:** All regular chats are stored in the cloud, making them accessible to Telegram or third parties.

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How to improve your privacy on Telegram

While Telegram isn't the most secure messaging app by default, you can take steps to make it more private. Each solution below includes what it is and how to implement it.

Use Secret Chats when needed

Secret Chats provide end-to-end encryption and can't be accessed by Telegram servers. To start one:

1. Tap a contact
2. Choose **Start Secret Chat**

Turn off cloud-based auto-downloads

This prevents media from being stored on Telegram's servers by default:

1. Go to **Settings > Data and Storage > Auto-Download Media**
2. Toggle off

Regularly delete messages and chat history

Deleting old chats limits exposure.

1. Long-press a chat
2. **Clear History** or **Delete Chat** to remove stored messages from both ends

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If you access Telegram from a browser, choose privacy-designed browsers like **Brave** or **Tor Browser** to reduce tracking.

Use a temporary or anonymous phone number

Instead of linking your real number, use temporary or privacy-focused phone services to sign up with more anonymity. Pair Telegram with NymVPN for full metadata protection

Using NymVPN connects you to a decentralized Noise Generating Mixnet that hides your internet traffic patterns and IP address — protecting you from ISPs, surveillance, and data brokers.

How does Telegram compare to other messengers?

While Telegram offers flexibility and convenience, apps like Signal provide stronger privacy by default. Signal uses **full end-to-end encryption**, doesn't store metadata, and is fully open-source.

But even Signal doesn't fully protect your network metadata. That's where pairing it — or Telegram — with a privacy-enhancing tool like **NymVPN** is your ultimate security.

Nym's verdict? Is Telegram worth the risks?

Telegram is a fast and versatile messaging app, but it's not built for privacy. The **lack of default end-to-end encryption**, partially closed-source code, and metadata exposure can leave users vulnerable.

If you're going to use Telegram, do so wisely. Always enable Secret Chats for sensitive messages and layer in additional protections like NymVPN to shield your traffic from surveillance and tracking.

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Protect your private messengers with NymVPN

Telegram: FAQs

What data does Telegram store about users?

Is Telegram suitable for political organizing or protests?

Can I use Telegram without sharing my phone number?

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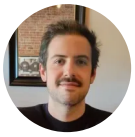
What are alternatives to Telegram for private messaging?

Can I use Telegram anonymously?

About the authors



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Ben is a core member of Nym's marketing team. He writes about privacy, security, and VPNs, helping users protect themselves from tracking and surveillance.

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Casey is the Head of Communications, lead writer at Nym, and editorial reviewer at Nym. He holds a PhD in Philosophy and researches the intersection of decentralized technologies and social life.

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